

and future greatness together, and aging becomes more powerful than the prior greatness, which eventually implodes foolishly. In medicine, “aged fragility” is a great frontier as a future, new recognized, disease but now it stops all old great investors. There simply are no great octogenarian investors. In his later years, Father could talk well and think well, but he didn't have the clarity for great decisions and his sales were poorly timed, consistently. Late in life, he would say things like he was looking for stocks he could hold for thirty years, which sounded silly for an eighty-five-year-old. People often thought it was charming, which was also pretty silly. I think a lot of other people knew he was doing this because he loved it and couldn't quit, even if it wasn't good for him financially. But he was indulged by everyone, including me. What did I care? If it made him happy, it was fine by me. But some could see that he was a bit like a man hanging around the ballpark with bat and glove when too old to play. His few late-in-life purchases were not successful. He would have been much better off financially if he had just quit doing anything at the age of eighty or even seventy. It wouldn't have mattered if he sold and went into index funds or just held what he owned until he died. As it was, his decisions detracted value steadily.

His long-held prescription for investors had been to buy great companies and pretty much hold them forever. And he had owned great companies. Had he followed his own prescription late in life and not attempted to fiddle and fix past his prime, he could have held what he owned until death and done far better than he did. I don't recall everything he ever owned, but I recall the main holdings. In 1973, at the market's peak, he owned among then-big firms in big amounts Dow Chemical, FMC Corporation, Motorola, and Texas Instruments. Among medium-sized companies in big amounts, he owned Raychem and Reynolds and Reynolds. Those six stocks then constituted two-thirds of his net worth. The biggest positions were Motorola, Texas Instruments, and Raychem; and had he held them all until now, despite the ravaging of the 2000–2002 bear market, he would have done very well. But with the exception of Motorola, they were all sold and the timing was terrible in every case, something he wouldn't have done if he was younger. Among smaller firms, he owned many, all selected between 1968 and 1973—and few did well for him after 1973. The most spectacular by far was a venture capital holding in Manufacturing Data Systems, which went public and then was acquired in the 1980's and in which he made a